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Witchcraft, oracles and magic among the Azande

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When Bögwözu, whose exploits are related in Part II, prepared medicine for his fellow witch-doctors to eat, some of them found it excessively bitter and noticed that Bögwözu was not partaking of the meal. They hinted their suspicions, remarking how strong and bitter was the medicine. Bögwözu said, 'So you are afraid to eat,' and he ate of the medicine himself. But Bögwözu and the other witch-doctors were not suggesting that the medicine might be poisonous in our sense of the word. They hinted that it might be bad medicine in the magical and moral senses explained in the first section of the next chapter. The same may be said of the leech's treatment for snakebite recorded on pages 502-3.

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It is not always easy to reconcile Zande doctrines with their behaviour and with one another. They say that men will sometimes eat fowls after having cleansed them of poison, and this action would imply a knowledge of the natural properties of *benge* that they refuse to allow in other situations. The owner of a dead fowl may have its stomach and neck removed and the fowl prepared for food. My informants said that they try to remove all the poison from the carcass. I do not know whether many men eat these fowls, but certainly some do. Probably the practice is rare, since as a rule chickens are used which are too small for culinary purposes. Generally the fowls are thrown away or placed in a tree for birds to devour after their wings have been cut off. Moreover, a young man would not eat fowls killed by the oracle, so that the statement applies only to old men, and perhaps only to those who are not very particular about their food. When I protested against the statement that persons eat poisoned fowls I was asked, 'What harm can it do a man since no one addresses it?' Mekana once remarked to me that it would be rather a joke to address the oracle poison in the belly of an elder who had

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eaten a fowl which had died in an oracle test. One might say, he suggested, 'If so-and-so (naming the elder) slept with his wife last night, poison oracle kill him.' I think that Mekana was hardly serious in this suggestion, but his joke taken together with the answer to my protest shows that Zande thought is concerned with mystical rather than natural properties of the oracle poison.

Nevertheless, the very fact of cleansing fowls of poison  318 suggests that Azande are to some extent aware of its natural properties. In fact they have ample knowledge to show them that *benge* is a natural poison that works regardless of taboos and spells—that is to say, if an educated European uninfluenced by Zande culture possessed their knowledge he would at once draw this conclusion. According to Mgr. Lagae, the *andegi* variety of the poison creeper is so called because *andegi* birds die when they eat of its flowers.¹ As we shall see later, some Azande hold that the poison will deteriorate with age, and all are aware that some poison is stronger than others and that it becomes more potent when exposed to the sun and less potent when diluted in water. They know that if a dog eats a fowl that has succumbed to the oracle it may die (it is possible that they conceive of the oracle still working inside the dog and answering the question put to it earlier, but I have no evidence that this is the case. It may also be possible that when men cleanse fowls killed by the oracle before eating them they are afraid lest the poison go on answering the question inside them and kill them. I have no doubt that a Zande might give so characteristically mystical a reason for his behaviour.)

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1 Lagae, op. cit., p. 85.

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